

■ B.1.3 Contexts

Every *Mathematica* symbol is associated with a particular *context*. The full specification of a *Mathematica* symbol is `context`name`. Context names can consist of any sequence of letters, digits, `$` and ```, but cannot start with either ``` or a digit. All context names must end with ```.

Built-in *Mathematica* symbols are in the context `System``. The default context for user-defined symbols is `Global``. Packages conventionally define symbols in a context whose name corresponds to the name of the package.

At any point in a *Mathematica* session, there is a *current context* `$Context`, together with a list of contexts `$ContextPath`. These allow symbols to be specified without explicitly giving their contexts. Functions like `Begin` and `End` change the current context.

<code>name</code>	search <code>\$Context</code> , then <code>\$ContextPath</code> ; create in <code>\$Context</code> if necessary
<code>`name</code>	search <code>\$Context</code> only; create there if necessary
<code>context`name</code>	search <code>context</code> only; create there if necessary
<code>`context`name</code>	search <code>\$Context`context</code> only; create there if necessary

Contexts used for various specifications of symbols.

It is conventional for packages to prepend their context to `$ContextPath`.

Context is included in the printed form of a symbol only if it would be needed to specify the symbol *at the time of display*.